

Χαμαιλέων ὁ Ἡρακλεώτης

Chamaeleon of Heraclea Pontica on Poetic Criticism

eul_aid: gww

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#) (phi, frg)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Πραγματεία](#) [Treatise](#)
Affiliation: [Peripatetic](#)

Chamaeleon of Heraclea Pontica was a Greek philosopher and writer who lived in the late 4th and early 3rd centuries BCE. He came from Heraclea Pontica, a city on the Black Sea coast in modern-day Turkey. He was a student of Aristotle and a member of the Peripatetic school, the philosophical circle that continued Aristotle's work.

While the details of his life are sparse, his scholarly work is significant. Chamaeleon did not write purely philosophical texts but instead pioneered a branch of Peripatetic scholarship focused on literary and cultural history. His writings were treatises that explored the lives, works, and customs of earlier Greek poets.

None of his works survive intact; they are known only through fragments quoted by later authors like Athenaeus. Based on these fragments, his known studies included works on major poets such as Aeschylus, Sappho, Stesichorus, and Pindar. He also wrote on broader cultural topics like On Drunkenness and specific literary forms like On Satyr Drama. According to modern scholars, his approach often blended biographical anecdote with criticism of the poetry itself.

Chamaeleon is considered an important forerunner of Hellenistic literary scholarship. His fragmentary works provide valuable, though sometimes anecdotal, insights into early Greek poetry and represent an early application of historical and empirical methods to the study of culture.

Works (2)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Μουσικῆς καὶ Γνωμῶν](#) · [Fragments on Music and Maxims](#) · 47 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ποητικῆς Κρίσεως](#) · [Fragments on Poetic Criticism](#) · 2 passages

Other Peripatetic Authors

- [Ἀγαθαρχίδης ὁ Κνίδιος](#) · [Agatharchides of Cnidus](#) · 4 works
- [Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἀφροδισιεύς](#) · [Alexander of Aphrodisias II](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀνδρόνικος ὁ Ῥόδιος](#) · [Andronicus of Rhodes](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος](#) · [Aristo of Ceos](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστόβουλος ὁ Ἰουδαῖος](#) · [Aristobulus the Jewish Philosopher](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστοκλῆς ὁ Μεσσηνίος](#) · [Aristocles of Messene](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀριστόμβροτος ὁ φιλόσοφος](#) · [Aristombrotus the Philosopher](#) · 1 work

- Ἀρίστων ὁ Κεῖος · Ariston of Ceos · 1 work
- Ἀσπάσιος ὁ Περιπατητικός · Aspasia the Peripatetic · 1 work
- Βοηθὸς ὁ Σιδώνιος · Boethus of Sidon · 1 work
- Κλέαρχος ὁ Σολεύς · Clearchus of Soli · 1 work
- Κριτόλαος ὁ Φασηλίτης · Critolaus of Phaselis philosopher · 1 work